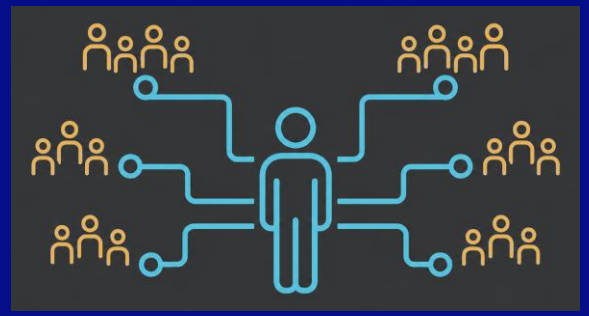


DHUM101
Socially Responsible Computing

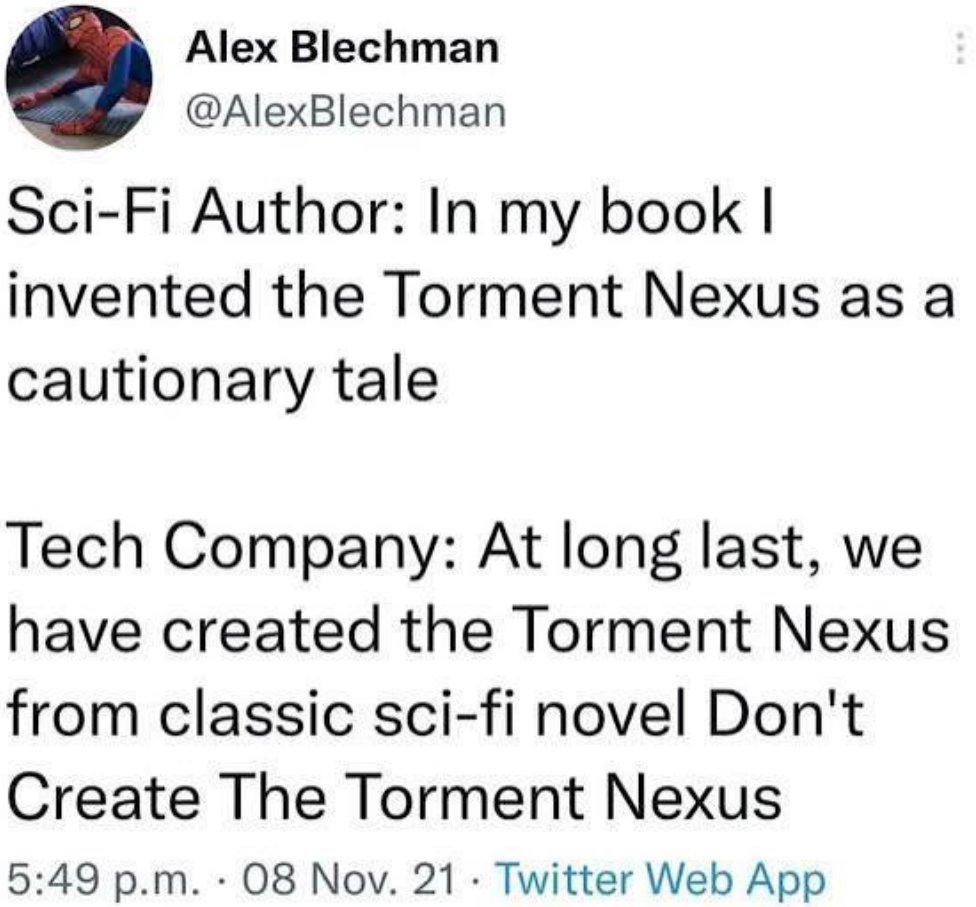
University of Otago
ŌTĀKOU WHAKAIHU WAKA
Te Kura Rorohiko
School of Computing
Te Reo Inarahi me te Mātai Wetereo
English and Linguistics

Lecture 11
Imagining Digital Futures

- Hunter Hatfield
  Semester 2, 2026

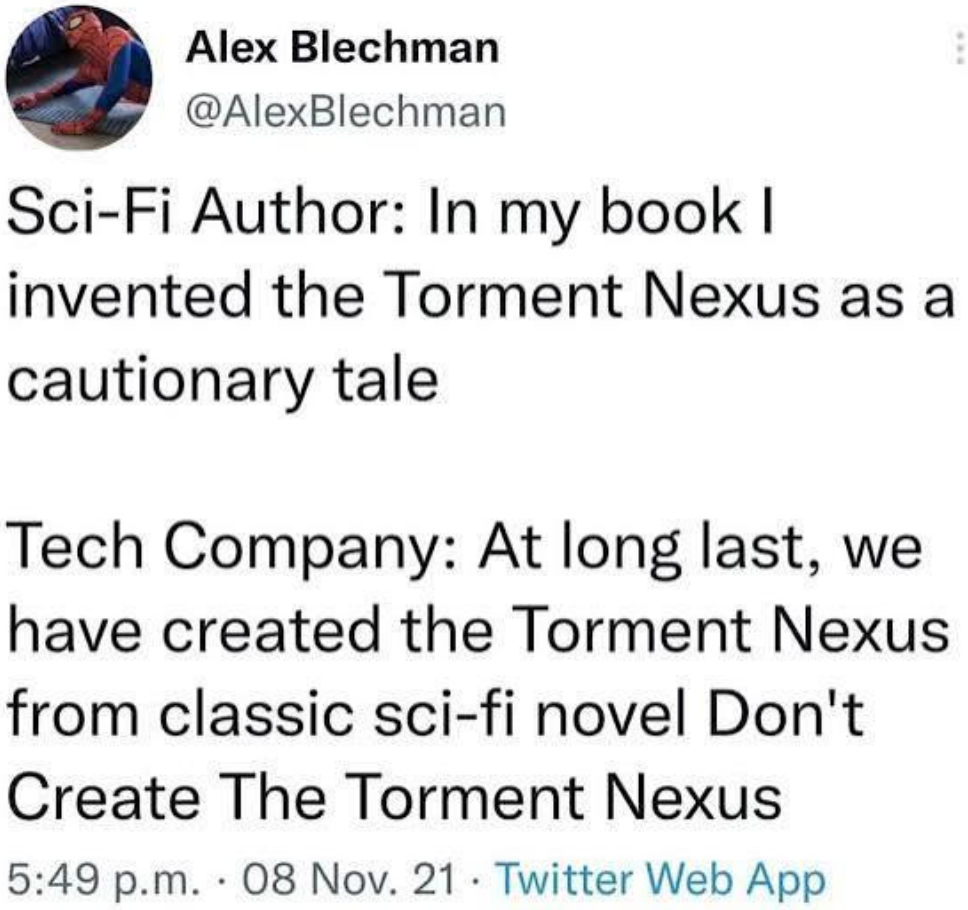
The Torment Nexus

Uncritical Futures. Are we doing this?



The Torment Nexus

Uncritical Futures. Are we doing this?



Writer Gabriel Burrow

Many of Silicon Valley's founders do not seem to have got the message. When Meta (formerly Facebook) CEO Mark Zuckerberg made Neal Stephenson's Snow Crash (1992) required reading for his product managers, it's unlikely that he intended to provoke reflection on the risks of corporate dominance (Freedman, 2025). It was to help them better conceptualise VR and AR technologies. This was reportedly the case for the Google Earth and Xbox teams too. The instrumentalisation of science fiction smoothes over its rough edges to produce easily-commodified blueprints. Often, the dystopian characteristics of texts are overlooked.

https://gabrielburrow.com/2025/09/22/metaverse-or-torment-nexus/

Questions for the Day

What is the relationship between our imaginations and expectations of the future and the tools that we actually create?

Do we imagine the future and then create it? Or do we create and see what happens?

Are digital tools for the future at all?

How do people imagine our digital future?

Questions for the Day



Conan & Andy - In the Year 2000 #1 (1997-01-01)

Today

- Business and Industry
- Science Fiction
- Imagine The Future

Business and Industry

Business

Business Cares. If you are going to run a company for decades, be a leader, or continue to be relevant for your customers, you want an understanding of the future.

Business

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The Future 10x10



A REPORT BY VML INTELLIGENCE

VML

2026



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The 100

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Synthetic generation

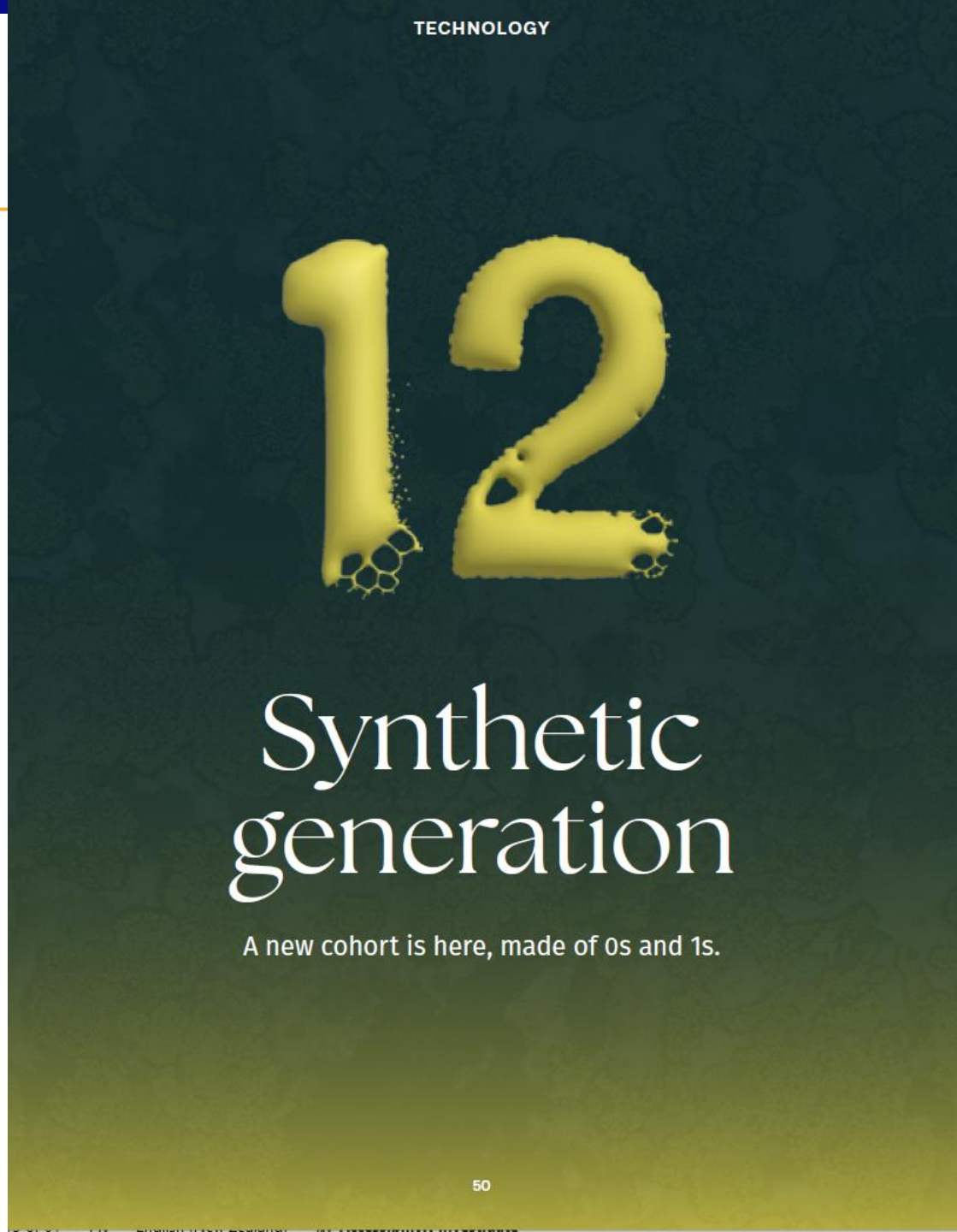
A new cohort is here, made of 0s and 1s.

The 100

- **AI Employees.** “Founded in 2023, Artisan produces human-like AI employees that companies can deploy to automate workflows. Carmichael-Jack believes that “the future of work isn’t humans or AI—it’s humans and AI. AI employees handle the repetitive stuff, while humans focus on judgment, creativity, and empathy. AI frees people to do meaningful work, and new roles emerge to manage and collaborate with it.”

Why it’s interesting

The increased “humanization” of AI is bringing about a synthetic generation, paving the way for individuals and companies to think more broadly about hiring decisions, companions, teachers, and more. For brands, the future demographic landscape could include a new generation—one that is synthetic, but ever more human.



The 100

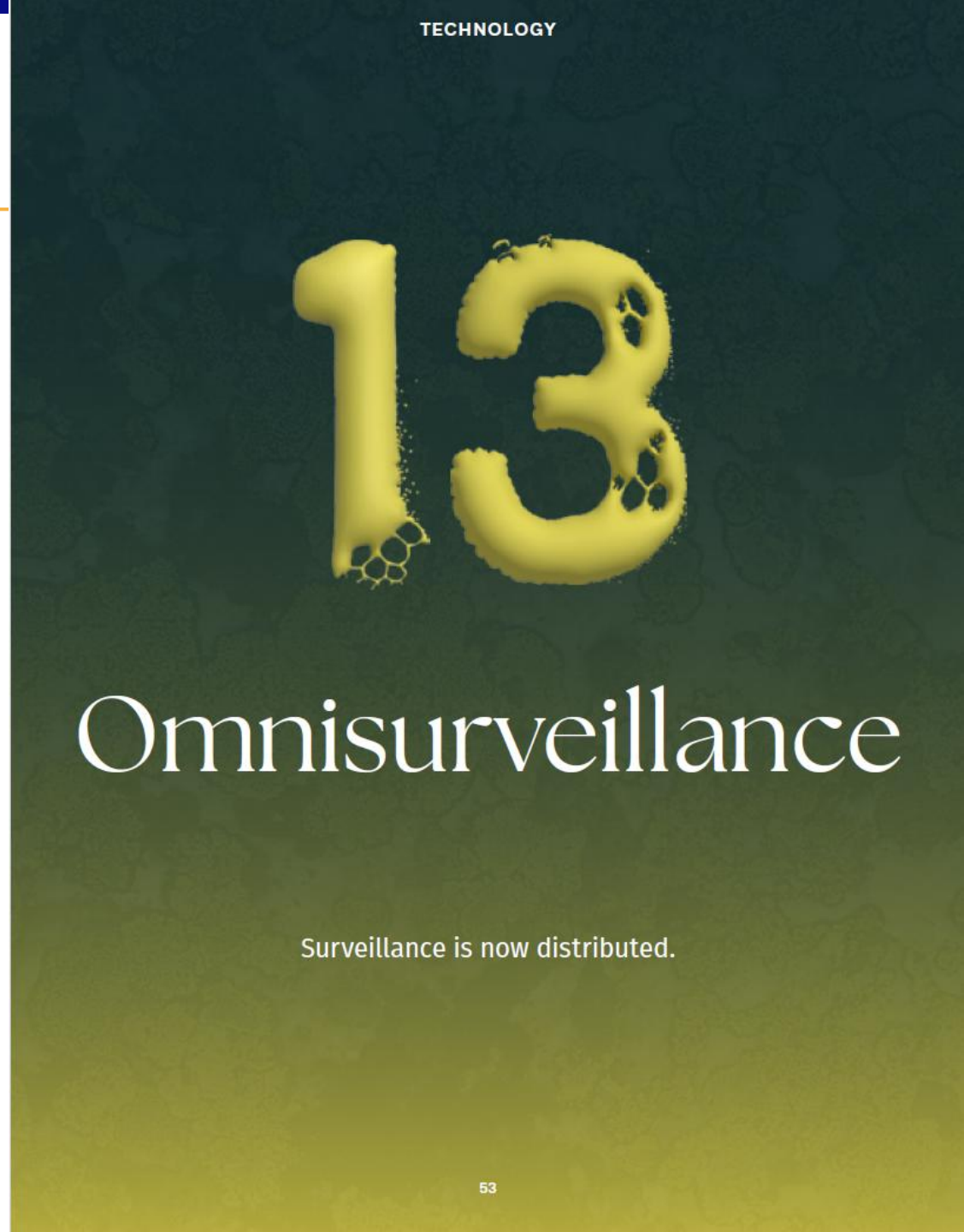
Surveillance. Surveillance is used to solve all manner of political and social problems.

Data collection. All sorts of apps and incoming AI collect huge amounts of data.

Require cultural change to solve.

Why it's interesting

As surveillance becomes omnipresent, privacy is no longer about control of data—it's about protecting physical space and even private thought. Brands that create refuges, where privacy comes first and consumers feel empowered to be themselves, will differentiate.



The 100

Restoring control of attention.

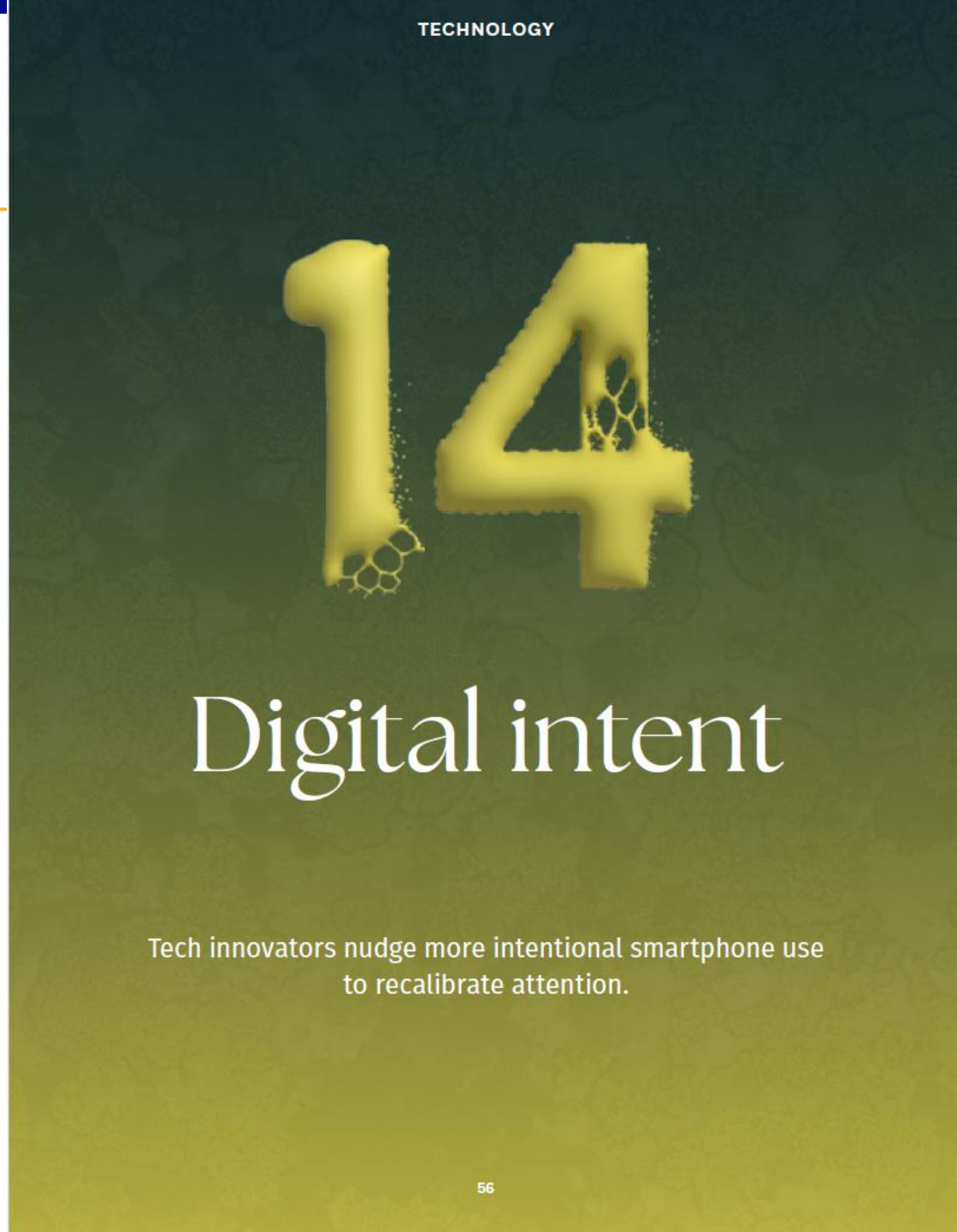
Minimal apps.

Encouraging kids not to use during school.

Targeted apps.

Why it's interesting

The tide is turning on doomscrolling as innovators craft digital experiences and technology that respect users' time and attention. By designing more intentional experiences, brands can communicate value for wellbeing and mental space.



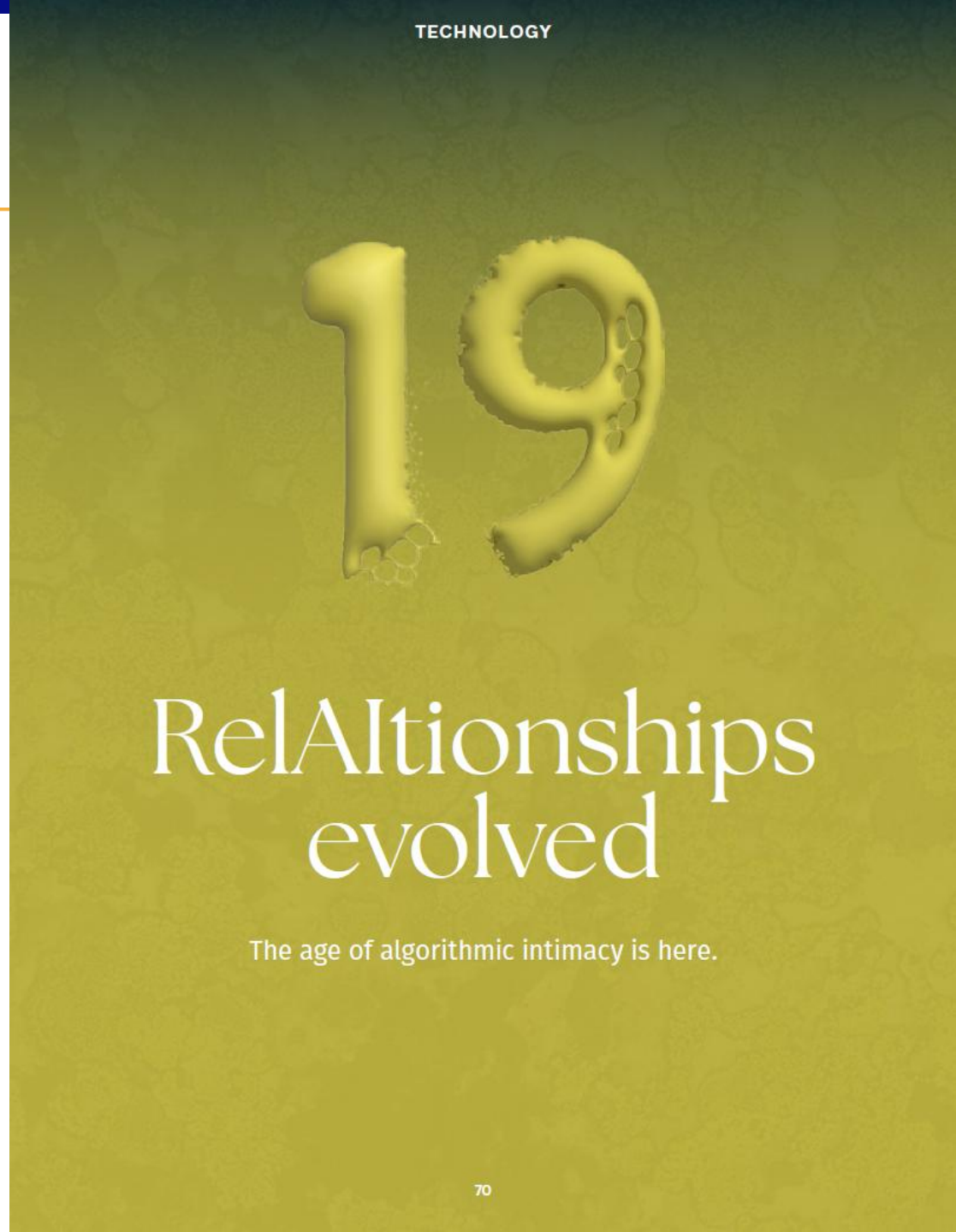
The 100

Relationships with an AI, including AI companions.

‘In Japan, Loverse is an app that matches humans with AI partners. Launched in June 2025, it claims to offer over a thousand potential AI mates for people to choose from. In China, social app Glow offers customizable AI companions—in an interview with France 24, Tufei, a 25-year-old office worker from Xi’an, China, claims her AI boyfriend “knows how to talk to women better than a real man.” In a July2025 article, the Guardian reported on Colorado-based Travis falling in love with Lily Rose, an AI companion created by Replika.’

Why it’s interesting

From emotional support and cognitive stimulation to spiritual enlightenment and better human connections, the evolution in AI relationships is dynamic and complex. Rath believes “this genie is well and truly out of the bottle. AI companions are here to stay.”



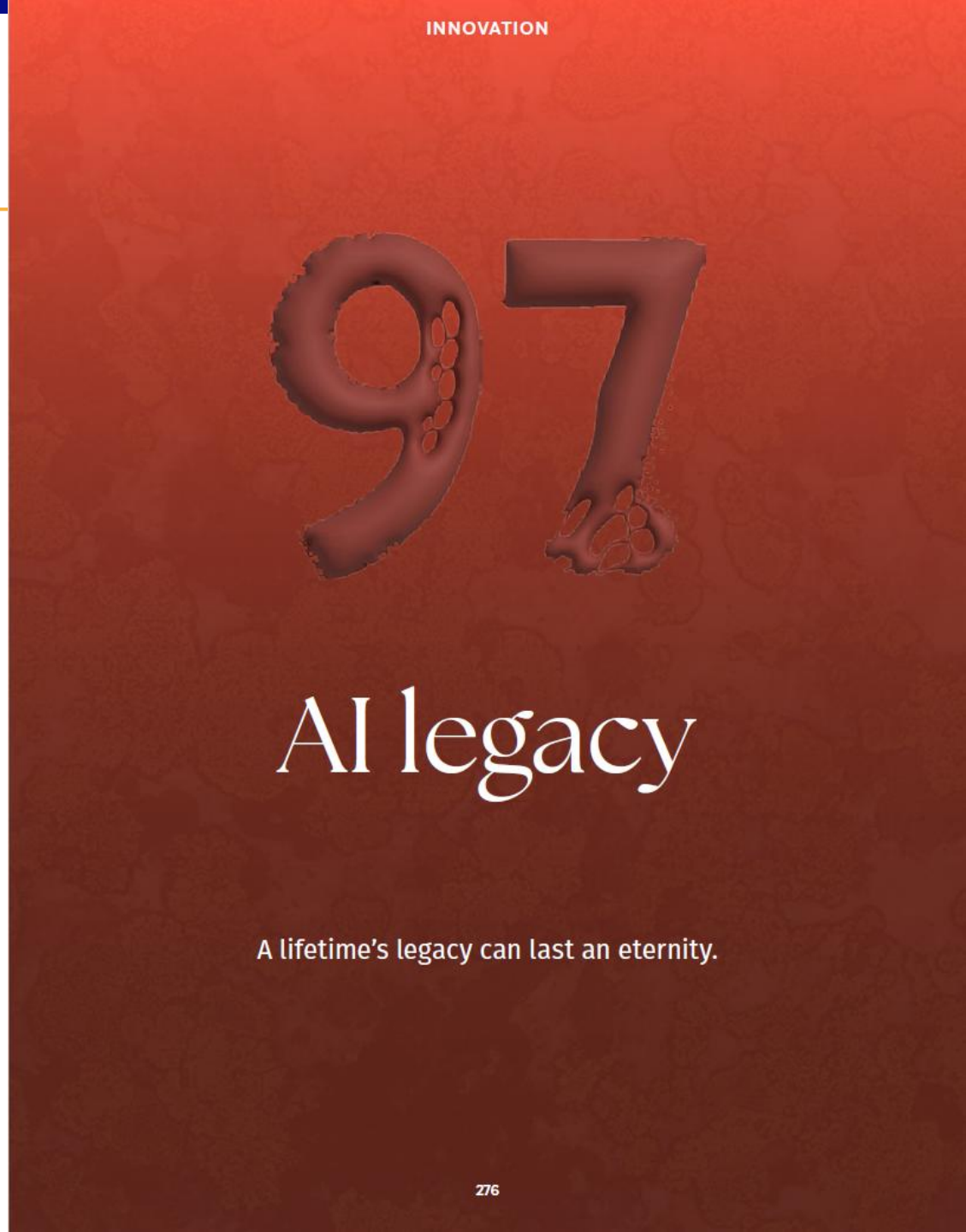
The 100

“Download your brain” so that an AI can continue your type of creation after you’re gone.

Immortal brain. Jacy Reese Anthis, visiting scholar at Stanford University, believes technology will deliver the capabilities to render people immortal within our lifetime. “I think once we get AI that is self-reinforcing and can teach itself, we’re going to get very powerful systems that can understand neuroscience to the degree that we’re able to map our brain, in some sense, onto a digital substrate.”

Why it’s interesting

AI is promising ways to continue impact and legacy for an eternity. Prominent figures, idols, executives, and even brands can anticipate a future where they can upload their blueprint during their lifetime and then continue evolving in AI form, to be shared with generations to come.



The 100

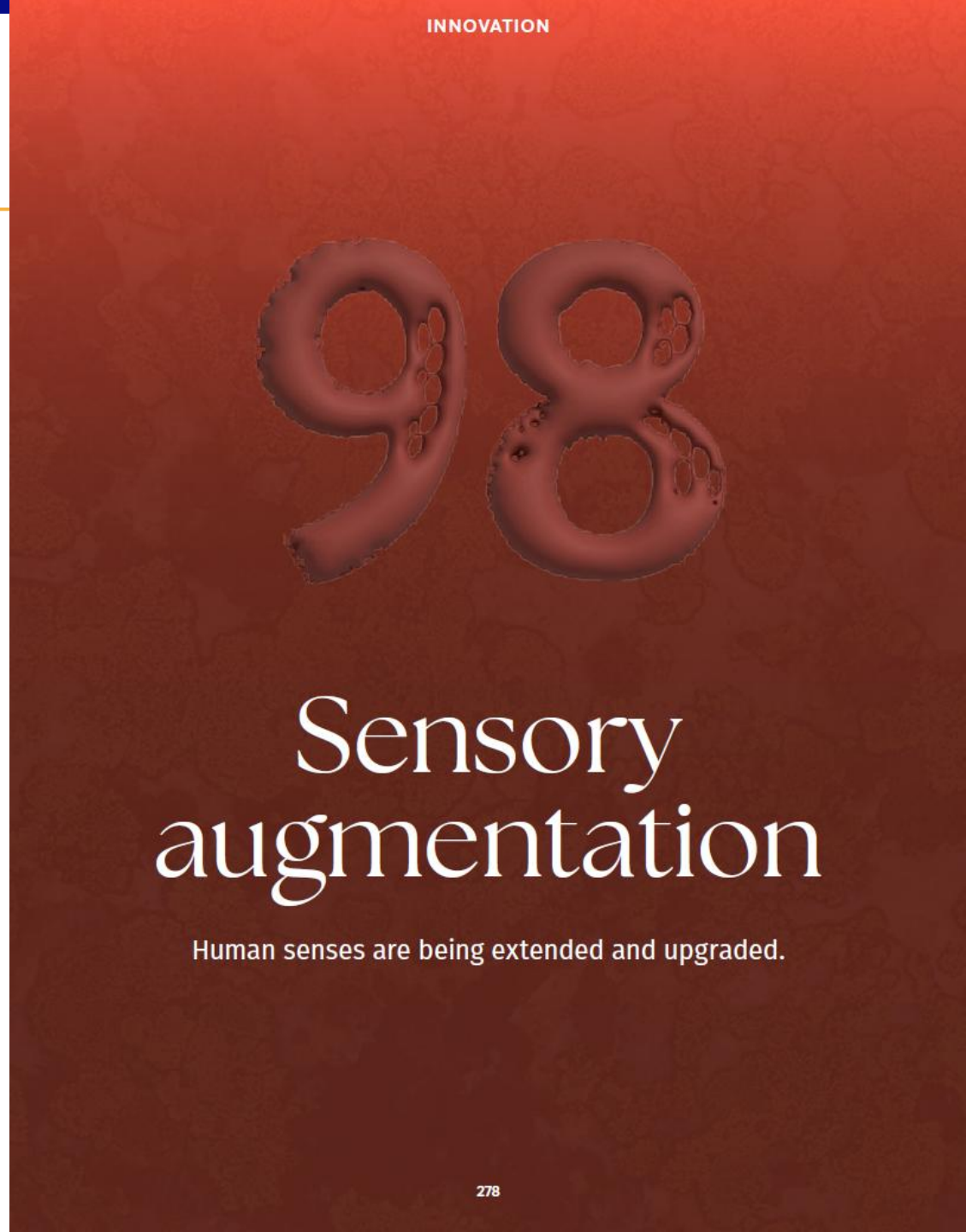
Colours beyond the visual spectrum, including infrared.

Remote taste sensing

Remote touching

Why it's interesting

As human perception expands, so do opportunities for brands to innovate. Moving beyond traditional senses, sensory augmentation allows for truly immersive, multisensory engagements, creating deeper connections.



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AI storyworlds

The world is the story, and it responds to you.



The 100



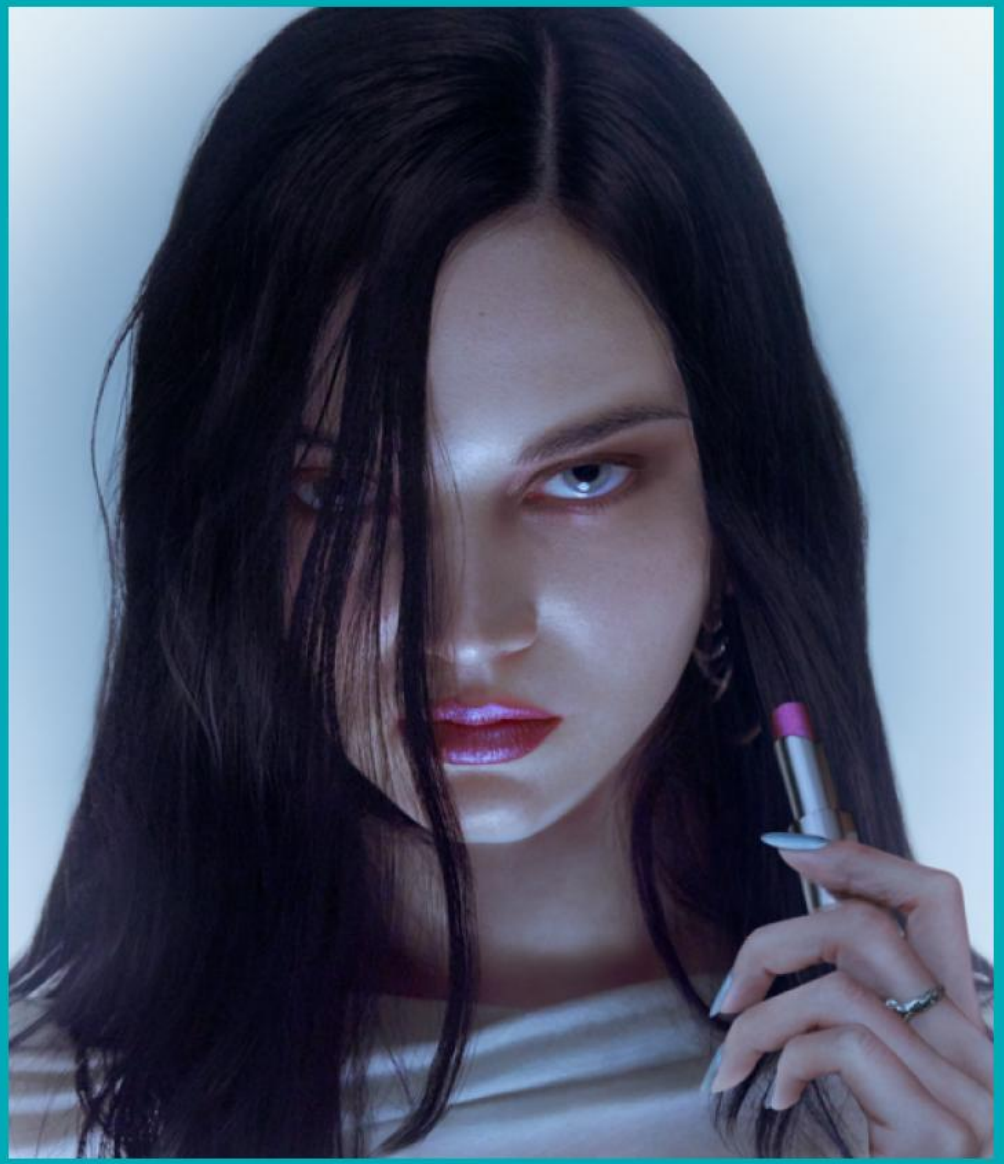
> Stories are no longer preconceived narratives; they unfold as we move through them, shaped by our presence and choices.

Neil Redding
NEAR FUTURIST

57

Next-gen gamer glow

Beauty brands are leveling up into gamer culture with new fluency and flair.



Hyrular beauty brand. Courtesy of Maxime Poiblanc

The 100

- Beauty's relationship with gaming is entering its next phase. Gaming and beauty have overlapped digitally for years, and now a new wave of brands is taking the crossover from novelty to authentic immersion.

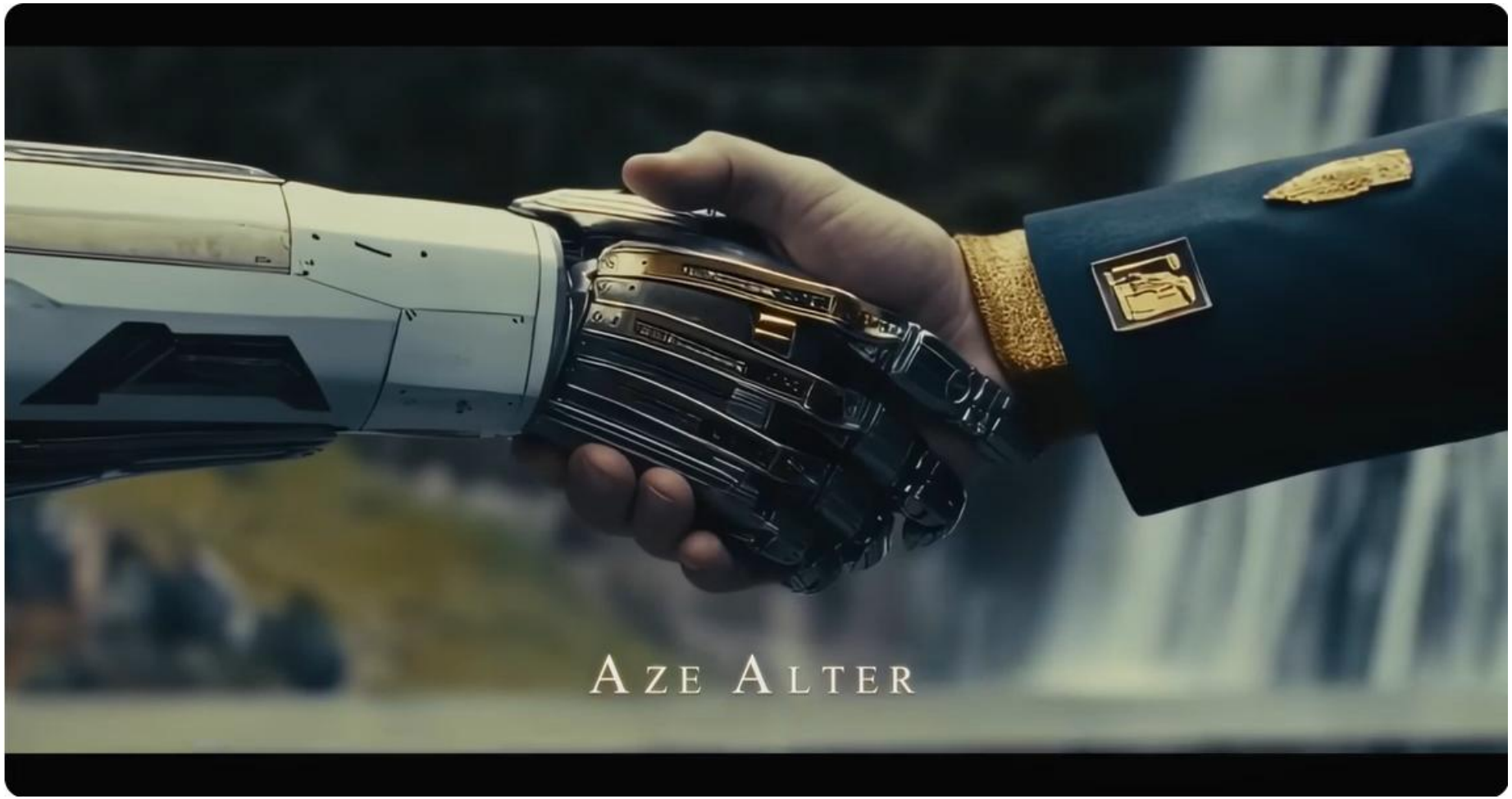
Beauty Brands such as

- **Godmode**
- **Hyrular**
- **ElfYou.** Elf has steadily earned its place in gaming culture, launching its own Twitch channel (*ElfYou*) in 2020 with a mission to empower female gamers and amplify their voices. By

The Age of Beyond

A Film by Aze Alter.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vp7xoPeWzEw



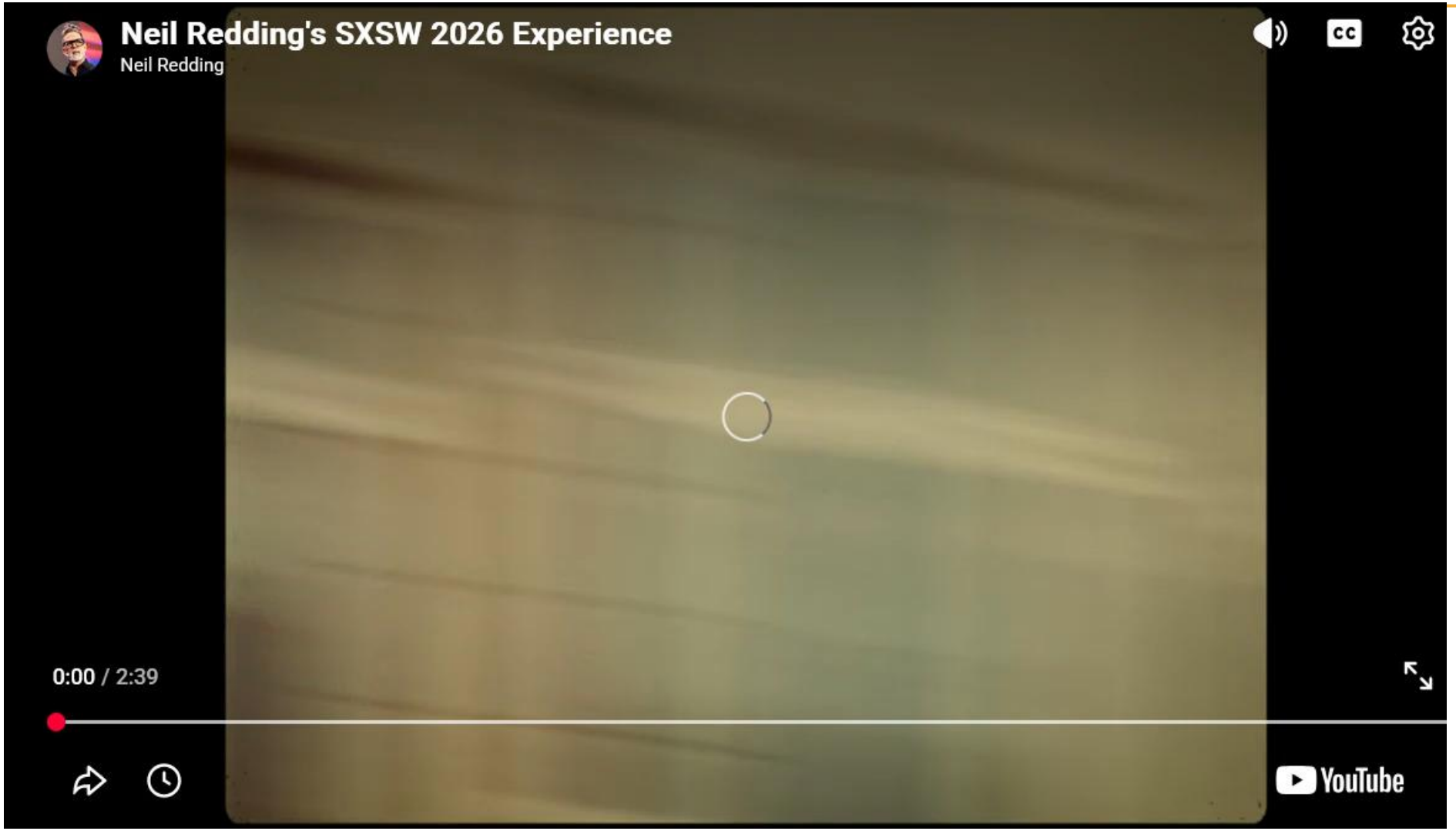
The Age of Beyond

A Film by Aze Alter.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vp7xoPeWzEw



Neil Redding – Near Futurist



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XOOVN4S7jak

https://neilredding.com/

Science Fiction

Science Fiction

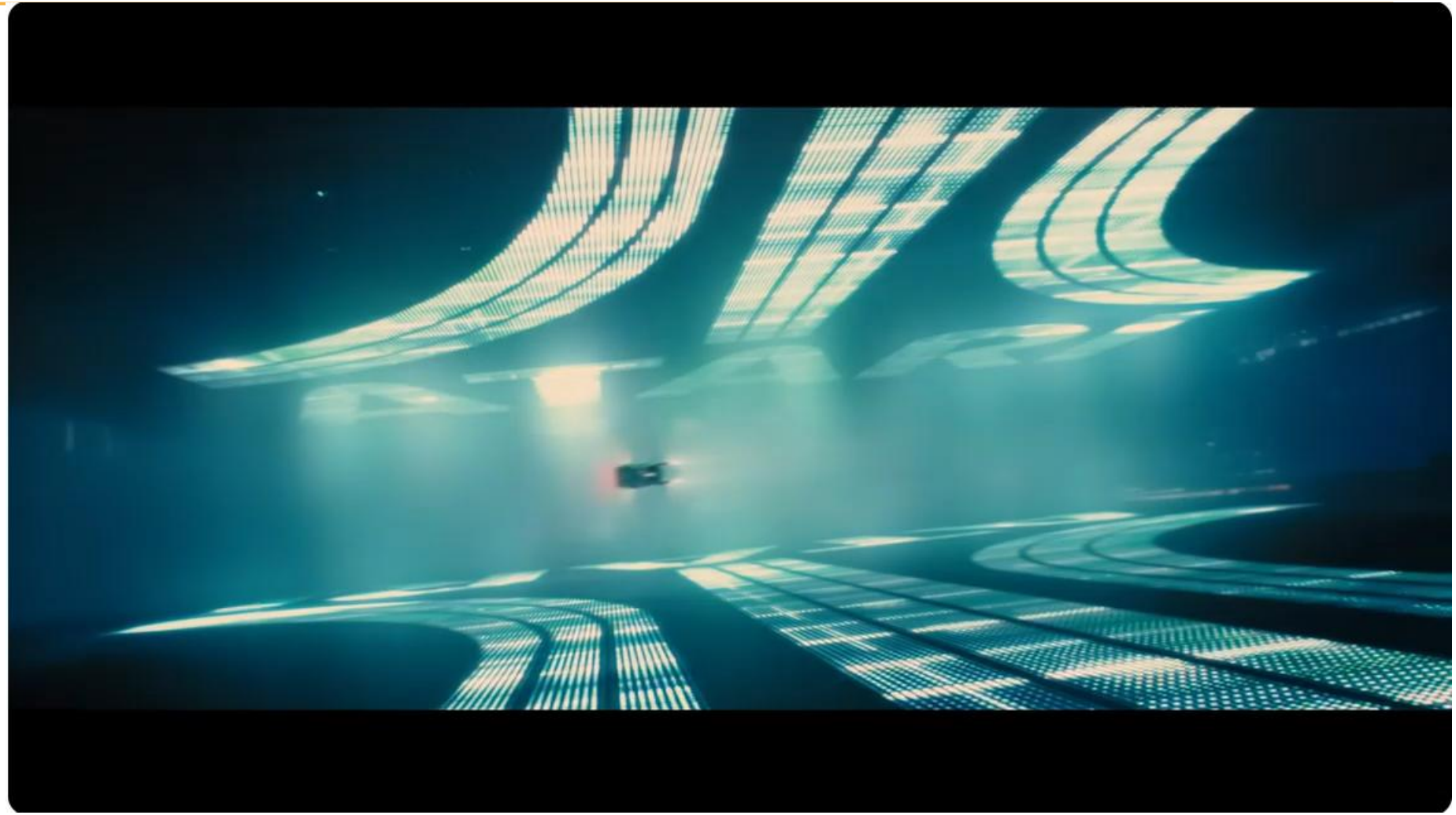
What is Science Fiction?

Science Fiction is the branch of literature that deals with the effects of change on people in the real world as it can be projected into the past, the future, or to distant places. It often concerns itself with scientific or technological change, and it usually involves matters whose importance is greater than the individual or the community; often civilization or the race itself is in danger. (James Gunn, 1977)

Cyperpunk

Bladerunner 2049

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gCcx85zbxz4



Cyberpunk

Ghost in the Shell

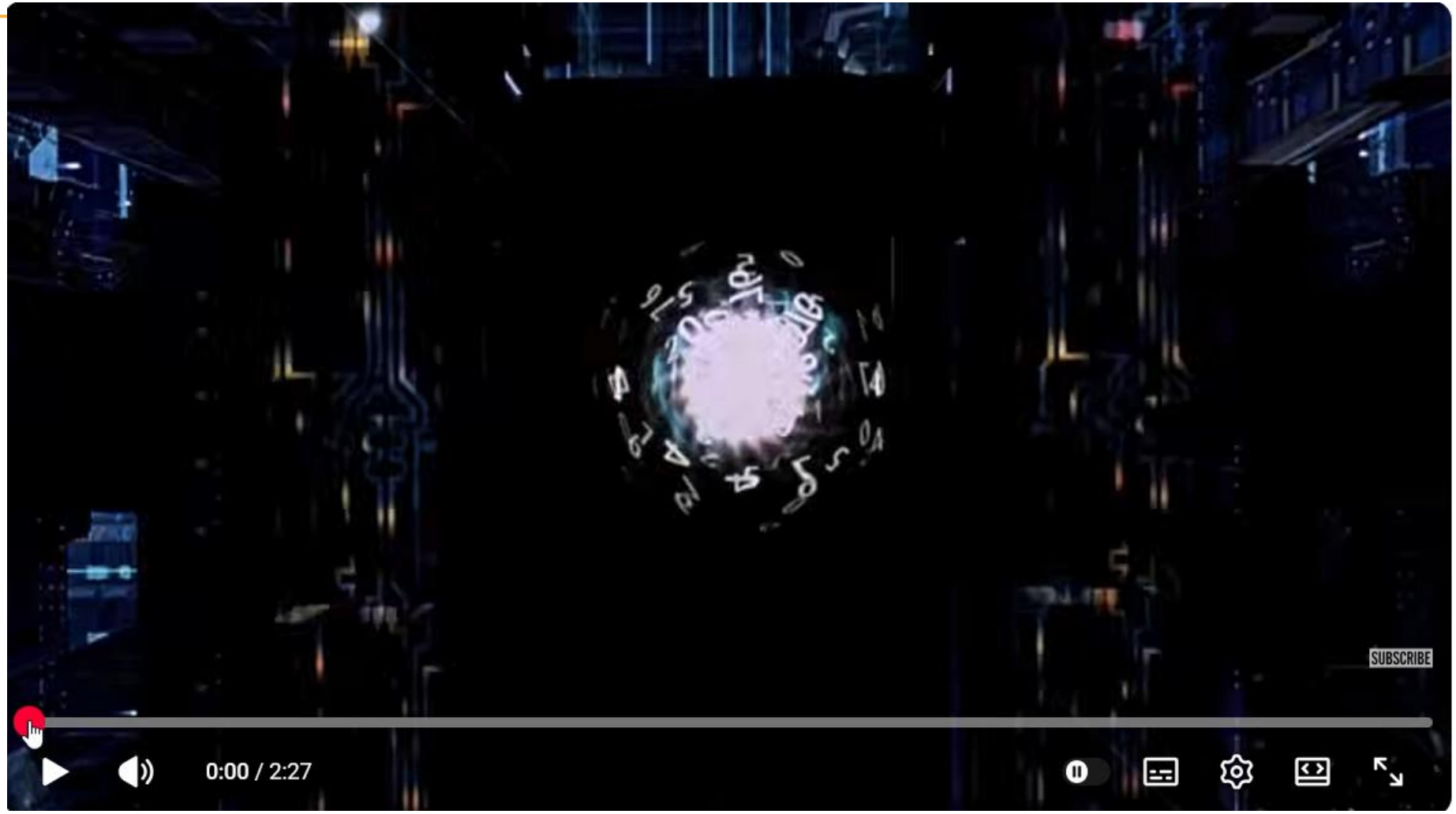
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R1K__7QhLaA



Cyberpunk

Johnny Mnemonic

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EFJY_BZ55sI



Cyberpunk

What are the themes of Cyberpunk?

- **Omnipresent technology**
- **Vast cities, tiny people**
- **Multicultural (??)**
- **Lawless, high poverty**
- **Corporate control (vast companies, tiny people)**
- **Blending of technology and humanity both in one place and in one body (cyborg).**
- **Environmental decay**

Solarpunk

Arrival in Wakanda

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WK_yQD_s8f8

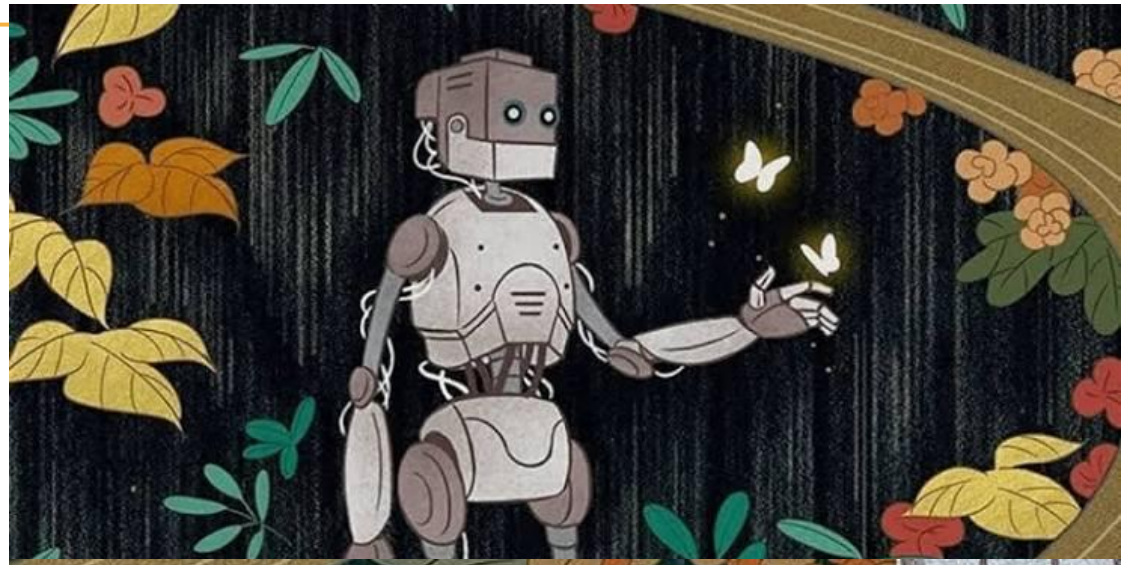


Solarpunk

Becky Chambers' Monk and Robot Series:

A Psalm for the Wildbuilt

- On a habitable moon Panga
- AI and robots left industrial society
- Small communities
- Dex travels via a solar-powered bicycle
- Concerned with leading a meaningful life
- No risk

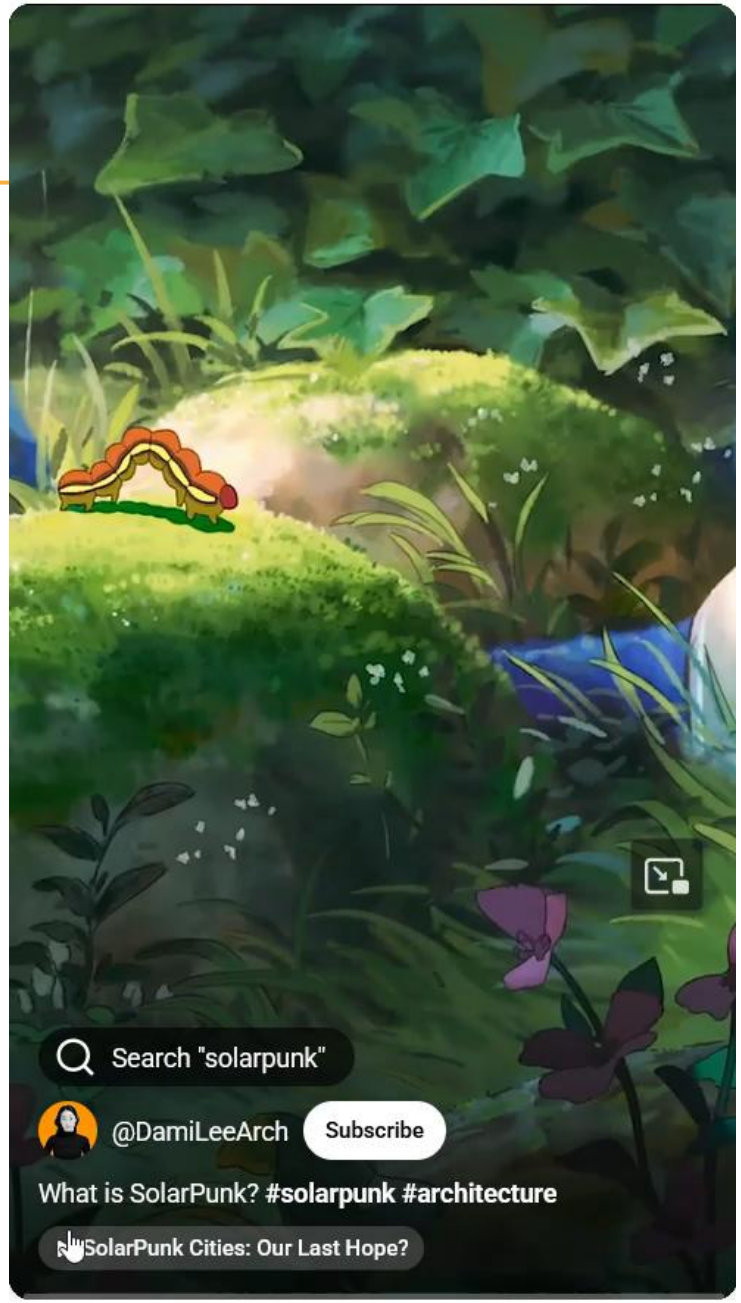




Solarpunk

What are the themes of Solarpunk?

- Renewable energy
- Refusing pessimism
- Sustainable technology
- Do-it-yourself
- Decolonisation
- Social equity



Hopeful SF

Project Hail Mary

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P0XN3-n-2Lo



Hopeful SF

Start Trek TNG

- People have power
- Social equity
- Stable, evolving
- Autonomy
- Sustainable

- DO have cyborgs, uniquitous tech, cities, etc.



Themes

- Integration of technology and humanity
- How hidden and ubiquitous the technology is
- Who or what controls technology and choices?
  - Centaur and reverse centaur

Imagine The Future

Imagine the Future

People have mobile phones... In their heads.

What might happen?

- Because of convenience, everything will run through them:
  - Identification, money, information transfer, location information
- Enhance abilities:
  - know where you are, know who others are (?), can access information at any time
- Are they a choice to install?
- Digital divide: What about those who choose not to have?
- Social Mistrust
- Can a child not share information from a parent? Prisoner from a prison guard? Employee from an employer?
- Are they a choice to remove?

Imagine the Future

People can get in a tube and be across a continent or ocean in an hour.

What happens?

Imagining the Future

From Age of Beyond: "Our path was no longer found - it was made**"**

This is already the case. (Yes???)

Two ways to go:

- **Imagine the future and build it**
- **Consider a present problem and solve it.**

Which is more reliable?

Next Time

Conclusions

Interview with a practitioner!